

Photographs by SUBIR HALDER



WARRING HORSES: Dalmiya (left) after winning the CAB elections and Mukherjee



"I could tell from the body-language of my so-called supporters that they didn't vote for me. I feel betrayed."

PRASUN MUKHERJEE, FORMER COMMISSIONER OF POLICE, WEST BENGAL

not vote for me. I have nothing to say really," he said. As Dalmiya's mobile phone began to ring with congratulatory calls of the officials and players from around the world (though none of the current BCCI office-bearers, he was quick to point), he was beaming and professing to modest ambitions. "Bengal cricket, and toning up the CAB administration," he said, "was topmost in his mind". The state's relegation to the Ranji Trophy was "one of our darkest hours," Dalmiya rued. The players "naturally... wanted to play in the elite group. They may look for a place in other state teams. We have to see how we can stem such movements."

With old aide K.K. Ghosh, who returned from the United States to be at his boss' side for the election, it did seem like old times. The BCCI's annual elections are due in a month and Dalmiya could be there casting his vote as CAB boss. As the September elections draw close, no doubt Dalmiya will gather around old allies like Arun Jaitley, Brijesh Patel, Amitava Chowdhury and Ranbir Singh Mahendra, if only to make the ruling lobby nervous.

In terms of actually staking a claim to major power again, there is nothing for Dalmiya to play for this year as Pawar loyalist Shashank Manohar is already nominated as the BCCI president-elect. But now he has the time, the motive and the opportunity to

work his way back towards the remote controls of the Indian Board. Dalmiya clucks impatiently at this theorising. "Let me make it clear, I have not come back for the sake of power. I have had a long and successful innings. This time I have come back to the CAB with a mission to improve the standard of cricket in the state."

His benign blueprints did contain within them, seeds of conflicts. He is keen to bring back senior Bengal players like Abhishek Jhunjhunwala, Deep Dasgupta, Rohan Gavaskar and Shib Sagar Singh from the Zee-backed rebel ICL. "We will talk to them and the Board and try to bring players back," Dalmiya said. At the moment, the ICL has full-fledged pariah status in the BCCI.

The alarm bells in the BCCI's corridors are beginning to ring and there are rumours that there will be attempts to ban Dalmiya and slap fresh court cases against him.

The man himself is sanguine. "I don't work on apprehensions. I can only say that I hope whatever they have against me, they fight it out with me. On a personal level I am ready. I hope they will not take it out on the association." As for his own national ambitions, he said, "I am out of touch with what is happening at the national level, I have no agenda," and then smiled. For some odd reason, Dalmiya's beam resembled the smile of the Cheshire cat in *Alice in Wonderland*. Remember it? The one that had eaten up all the cream? ■

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?

■ The ruling lobby in the BCCI gets the heebie-jeebies and tries to formulate plans to ban Dalmiya using legal levers

■ Dalmiya lies low during the September BCCI election as a president-elect is already in place, but rallies his old allies

■ By making the reinstatement of Bengal's rebel ICL players a priority, Dalmiya could set up his first direct clash with BCCI

■ By openly voicing his disapproval of the sidelining of state cricket officials during the IPL, a war of words between Dalmiya and Lalit Modi is in the offing